

Desk Research — Evidence of Current Ticketing Friction

Team 27 · Grand Prix Ticketing Redesign · Sprint 1, Week 1 · 20 August 2026

1. Purpose and method

The client has not specified a problem to solve. This research is the first step in identifying one: gathering published evidence of where the current Formula 1 Australian Grand Prix ticketing experience causes difficulty for buyers. Six independent public sources were reviewed — motorsport trade press, national broadcast news, specialist F1 commentary and consumer guidance. Recurring issues were grouped into themes rather than recorded as individual complaints, so the output points to systemic problems rather than isolated incidents. This is desk research only; no primary user interviews were conducted at this stage.

2. Theme A — The on-sale window fails under peak load

The highest-volume moment in the entire customer lifecycle is also the least reliable. The general public on-sale for the 2025 Australian Grand Prix was delayed by a global third-party Ticketmaster outage, and online queues exceeded 100,000 people. The event then sold out in under an hour. The pattern is not unique to F1 in Australia: ticketing platforms here have a documented history of buckling during high-demand sales, including cases where buyers paid and were left without tickets. The consequence is that a buyer's first experience of the event is a queue, an error, or a failure — before any value has been delivered.

Evidence: Colitco (Ticketmaster outage, AGP on-sale delay) · Speedcafe (2025 on-sale, demand exceeded supply) · TicketGrandPrix (sold out under one hour; queues above 100,000).

3. Theme B — Pricing was opaque and lost the audience's trust

The event previously used demand-based ("dynamic") pricing, which at times sold tickets well above face value. Critics argued this let the promoter raise prices beyond the ten per cent cap that applies to public resale, and characterised it as price gouging on the most sought-after seats. Coverage by ABC News reported Australian Grand Prix ticket prices tracking towards AFL Grand Final levels. The organiser has since announced it will drop demand-based pricing for 2026, and the Australian Grand Prix Corporation has publicly acknowledged it is exploring solutions to ticketing complaints. That the promoter reversed the policy is itself strong evidence that the friction was real and material.

Evidence: Speedcafe (AGP ditches demand-based pricing for 2026) · MotorRacing.com (same, with criticism summarised) · ABC News, 20 Sep 2025 (price rises vs AFL Grand Final) · Speedcafe (AGP exploring ticket complaint solutions).

4. Theme C — Buyers cannot easily tell what they are buying

A substantial secondary market of explainer content exists purely to help people decide between general admission and a grandstand seat — which is itself a signal that the official purchase path does not answer the question. The decision carries real financial weight: single-day general admission at Albert Park sits around AU\$120, while a reserved race-day grandstand seat comfortably exceeds AU\$400. Guidance notes that grandstand seats do not always deliver a better view than general admission and are mainly worth the premium if a reserved seat matters to the buyer. A once-a-year buyer, unfamiliar with the circuit layout, is therefore making a three-to-four hundred dollar decision without the information needed to make it well.

Evidence: The F1 Spectator (grandstand vs general admission comparison, pricing) · Formula1.com (official visitor information for Albert Park) · Time Out Melbourne (event and ticket overview).

5. What this means for the project

Themes A and B are largely commercial and platform decisions sitting with the promoter and its ticketing vendor — outside what this team can change in twelve weeks on free-tier infrastructure. Theme C is a design and information problem, and it is squarely within our reach. It is also the theme most likely to be validated by the journey map, because it sits in the pre-purchase stage where the attendee is still deciding.

Recommendation: carry Theme C forward as the leading candidate for the Week 2 How Might We workshop, while keeping A and B on the board as context the client should be aware of.

6. Limitations

All evidence is secondary and drawn from public reporting; no primary research with attendees has been carried out. Coverage skews towards the 2025 event and towards buyers vocal enough to appear in press or review content, so quieter forms of friction may be under-represented. The client has not yet shared internal customer feedback, complaint logs or analytics — if provided, these would materially strengthen the problem definition before Sprint 2 begins.

7. Sources

#	Source	Used for
1	Speedcafe — Australian GP exploring F1 ticket complaint solutions	Theme A, Theme B
2	Speedcafe — Australian GP ditches demand-based ticket pricing	Theme B
3	ABC News (20 Sep 2025) — F1 ticket prices on track to eclipse AFL Grand Final	Theme B
4	MotorRacing.com — Australian GP ditches demand-based pricing	Theme B
5	Colitco — Ticketmaster global outage frustrates Australian F1 fans	Theme A
6	TicketGrandPrix — 2025 Australian Grand Prix sold out in one hour	Theme A
7	The F1 Spectator — Grandstand vs General Admission	Theme C
8	Formula1.com — Helpful information when visiting Albert Park	Theme C

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